

Putrefaction

What do you do with a rotting banana? Do you leave it on your kitchen counter, forgotten, until spring cleaning comes around, just to discover it's a mushy mass? Do you watch as it darkens into brown spots that spreads over its surface, mold forming at the stem? Let it become this desiccated, nasty thing only because it was the last one left from its bunch?



Prehension – an interaction of a subject with an event or entity which involves perception but not necessarily cognition

When I was little, I had a unibrow stretching over the space of the bridge of my nose. The furry line was the first thing I often noticed in the mirror or in pictures, the gap between my two front teeth second. This unibrow accentuated the already dark, angular nature of my brows, adding to the rest of the masculine features of my face. It was around this time I learned I was scheduled as a C-section well before my birth, due to the broad span of my shoulders. If my mother had me naturally, my shoulders would have cracked her pelvis in half on my way out.



What do you do with a rotting banana? Do you see it on your kitchen counter and toss it in the garbage without a second thought, covering it in waste from the food you do choose to eat, the paper towels you used to clean up its mess? Or do you poke and prod at its flesh, seeing how it bruises from a gentle touch? Scratch shapes and letters and secrets into its skin and let them brown a shade darker than the rest of it, only to throw it away all the same?



Lividity – the discoloration of skin

When I was 12 or 13 or 14, a family friend took my jaw in her hand, her fingers brushing across my lower mandible, and said, “You know how I can tell you’re growing up? Your jawline has softened. It’s so much more graceful.” But even with a rounder chin, I still possessed the silhouette of a rugby player. I was shoved into every defense and goalie position possible. From my post in the crease, box, or behind the halfcourt line, I would watch my teammates weave their way through opponents with grace, with ease, and to the goal. I thought what it would be like to be slender, to flow like water down field. The few times I was put in the place to carry myself to the opposing goal, I felt like an earthquake, a mudslide, an onslaught of rain before the eye of a hurricane.

With all of these masculine traits and my boyish stature, I gravitated toward the boys in my grade. Their energy matched mine: the need to get muddy at recess, throw a dodgeball with all my might at the person catty-corner from me in foursquare. The restless feeling of taking out your anger on something else was welcome within these groups, excused even. Hanging out with the girls in my grade meant weird looks when I’d fling myself from the monkey bars and roll into the mulch, when I’d sit in dirt and wet grass, when I’d laugh too loudly or speak too crudely. I thought, for a while, this made me better than my feminine counterparts—my ‘bond’ with boys, my knee-length shorts and chin-length hair. This only divided me from them more.

In middle school, during a game of telephone in class, my tongue worked too freely in my mouth and out came a secret of one of my close friends as the phrase to be passed around. I don’t know if it was for attention, the shock value, or what, but it came out and I regretted it. By the time the phrase came back to me, the words, “Sydney looks like she’s trans,” snaked their way through my ear canal and made a home for themselves in my mind, setting the course of my

identity crisis. I felt trapped. My expression of self was being perceived and questioned, shamefully so. It was here I began to understand that to the other 13-year-olds in my life, basketball shorts and broad shoulders did not go together on a girl. The fact that I even attempted to do so invalidated the little girlhood I possessed.

I decided to cover up my frame with sweatshirts two sizes too big to avoid any more comments from my peers. I wasn't happy with the same three pairs of leggings I had on rotation, but at least I was hiding my frame; fitting into the 'feminine' stereotype outlined for me.



What do you do with a rotting banana? Do you see its disgusting casing and decide you need rid of it? Or do you peel back its marred skin, air out its insides, and see if it's still good? What do you do with a rotten banana? Think about it. What do you do with the thing on your counter that has separated from itself, cell by cell?



Abscission – the detachment of organs through specialized cell layers that activate modification and degradation of cell walls in response to stimuli, resulting in cell separation

By the time I graduated high school, I had branched out into loose jeans and boxy hoodies. It was an upgrade from black leggings and the same sweatshirt every day. It was more stylized, and I hunted for pants that wouldn't cling to my butt or hips at every thrift store in town. The funny thing was even though my expression was blatantly non-feminine, people around me saw it as

identity affirming. How they saw my basketball shorts and athletic socks in middle school was an unapproved diversion from the norm. Now, it seemed to them as though I had found myself.

The term *masc* was used to describe me in the circles in college I found myself in. Finally, was I able to explore my queerness and at the time, it meant being in touch with those sharp, brooding ‘quirks’ of mine. I basked in this attention, happy to have a positive ‘label’, whether I liked it or not. Quickly, though, I became discontent with this word, this identity, this *idea* that I was any certain thing. Again, external entities were dictating how I felt; but, instead of digging a little deeper into my psyche, I let it fester and swell in the back of my brain.

I began to crave that external approval, and I found it easiest in the dregs of dating apps. And though I promised myself when I was younger, I would never put my worth below the satisfaction of a man, it all came crumbling down when a *man*—not a boy—called me pretty, even in my basketball shorts. How validating it was for a man to tell me he liked the feminine parts of me dressed in the masculine that had begun to emerge from the depths of the hole I shoved them into. The first time I found myself wildly and desperately seeking male validation, exploiting those sacred and secret and coveted parts of myself, I cried.



What do you do with a rotting banana? When its juices and isoamyl acetate secretions have tainted all of the fruits and vegetables around it, when everything you eat from the fruit bowl or fridge or countertop tastes like it? When you have its flavor lingering in your mouth, sticking to your taste buds? Did you know a rotting banana can still be good on the inside, even though its peel is disintegrating and falling apart into the marble of your countertop? Its insides can be

perfectly that almost white color; still good enough to be eaten, gnashed between your teeth, good enough to be used in a smoothie or mashed into dough as a substitution for eggs?



Mastication – the process of breaking down food into smaller particles with the use of teeth and muscles

Putting on a skirt still feels wrong to me; my thighs bare without the layer of denim or polyester between them. It's sacrilegious, almost. I think of my kid self and I step out of the circle of fabric pooled around my feet, feeling like I'm drifting from who I am, who I was. I'll go to put on jeans and stop with the waistband at my shins, letting them fall to the floor. These are the days I opt for the sweatpants I thrifted four years ago, so many sizes big I still fit into them. There are days I put on makeup and immediately take it off. There are days I look in the mirror and see the blocks of my eyebrows, the droop of my right eyelid over my eye, the bulge of my traps, and I flinch away from my reflection. I regularly wage this battle with the expression of my identity, but as I grow, there are more and more days where these two sides are at peace. And on these days, I embrace the mascara and the glitter and the lip gloss. On these days, I embrace the pimpled face and baggy pants. On these days, which do still come, I am okay with the hair above my lip and the width of my shoulders under shirts much shorter and tighter than I've ever worn. On these days, my skin is no longer mottled, and my flesh is no longer bruised.